

KERALA ORIGIN

Avial

Mixed Vegetables in Coconut-Yogurt Sauce
The Centerpiece of Kerala's Onam Feast

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Avial

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dish Born of a Legendary Improvisation

Kerala food tradition tells a well-loved story about avial's origin: during the Mahabharata epic, Bhima — one of the five Pandava brothers living in disguise during their exile — is said to have thrown together whatever odd vegetable scraps he could find into a single dish while cooking for King Virata's court, creating avial on the spot. Whether or not the legend holds historical water, it captures something true about the dish's spirit: a resourceful medley of many different vegetables, bound together by coconut, that turns variety itself into the point.

Modern avial typically combines at least seven or eight different vegetables — drumstick, raw banana, yam, carrot, beans, and pumpkin among the most common — cut into similar-sized batons and cooked together with a coconut and yogurt (or raw mango, in some versions) paste, finished with a generous drizzle of raw coconut oil and curry leaves rather than a hot oil tempering, a distinctive technique that sets it apart from most other South Indian curries.

Avial holds a place of particular honor at Onam, Kerala's major harvest festival, where it's a required component of the sadya — the elaborate vegetarian feast served on a banana leaf — standing as one of the dishes most associated with Kerala's culinary identity both within India and internationally.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dish Born of a Legendary Improvisation, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Connected in Kerala food tradition to a popular Mahabharata legend involving Bhima improvising the dish during his exile, though this remains folklore rather than documented history. An essential component of the Onam sadya, Kerala's elaborate banana-leaf harvest festival feast. Distinguished by its finishing technique — raw coconut oil and curry leaves stirred in at the end rather than a hot tempering, unusual among South Indian curries. One of the dishes most closely associated with Kerala's culinary identity, both within India and internationally.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

20m	25m	6	Med
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Large, wide pot
- Small blender, for the coconut paste
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Avial keeps refrigerated for up to 3 days and, unusually for a yogurt-based dish, holds up reasonably well to reheating if done gently. It doesn't freeze well, given the yogurt and fresh coconut base.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the vegetables

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Raw banana (plantain), cut into batons	1	120 g	1
Yam, cut into batons	1 cup	150 g	1 katori
Carrot, cut into batons	1	80 g	1
Drumstick (moringa), cut into 2-inch pieces	1	80 g	1
Green beans, cut lengthwise	1 cup	100 g	1 katori
Pumpkin, cut into batons	1 cup	130 g	1 katori
Cucumber, cut into batons — optional	½ cup	60 g	½ katori

For the coconut paste

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Fresh coconut, grated	1 cup	100 g	1 katori
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Green chili	3–4	3–4	3–4
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach

To finish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Plain yogurt, whisked	½ cup	120 g	½ katori

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

To finish (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Coconut oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Curry leaves	2 sprigs	15–20 leaves	2 sprigs
Salt	1½ tsp	9 g	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Yam and raw banana can be difficult to find outside India — yam is sometimes available frozen at South Asian grocers, and a firm, unripe regular banana or plantain can substitute for raw banana. Feel free to adjust the vegetable combination based on what's available; the spirit of avial is variety and resourcefulness rather than a fixed recipe. Coconut oil is important for authentic flavor in the finishing step, though a neutral oil can substitute if needed.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Vegetables

01 CUT ALL VEGETABLES TO SIMILAR SIZES

Cut all the vegetables into similar-sized batons, roughly 2 inches long and ½ inch thick — this uniformity is important for even cooking and the dish's traditional presentation.



02 COOK THE FIRMER VEGETABLES FIRST

In a large pot, combine the yam, drumstick, and carrot with a small amount of water and turmeric. Cook covered for 8–10 minutes, until just starting to soften.

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Cooking the Vegetables, continued

03 ADD THE REMAINING VEGETABLES

Add the raw banana, beans, pumpkin, and cucumber if using. Continue cooking covered for another 8–10 minutes, until all vegetables are tender but still holding their shape.

Chef tip. avial's vegetables should be tender but distinctly firm, not mushy — check with a fork periodically to avoid overcooking.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The vegetables should be tender enough to eat comfortably but still hold their baton shape clearly — avial is not meant to be a soft, broken-down stew.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Coconut Paste and Finish

04 MAKE THE COCONUT PASTE

Coarsely grind the coconut, cumin seeds, and green chilies together — a slightly textured, not perfectly smooth, paste is traditional for avial.

05 ADD THE COCONUT PASTE TO THE VEGETABLES

Stir the coconut paste into the pot of cooked vegetables, along with salt. Simmer gently for 3–4 minutes to let the flavors combine.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Coconut Paste and Finish, continued

06 STIR IN THE YOGURT

Remove from heat and stir in the whisked yogurt — adding it off the heat prevents it from splitting.

07 FINISH WITH RAW COCONUT OIL

Drizzle the coconut oil over the top and add the curry leaves, stirring gently to combine. This raw finish, rather than a hot tempering, is what gives avial its distinctive aroma.

Texture and aroma indicator. the finished avial should smell distinctly of raw coconut oil and curry leaves — this uncooked finishing touch is essential to the dish's authentic character.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding the yogurt while the pot is still over direct heat is a common cause of splitting. Always remove from heat first, then stir in the yogurt.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as part of the Onam sadya, a required component of Kerala's elaborate banana-leaf harvest feast.
- Served with rice as a comforting, everyday Kerala meal beyond festival occasions too.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl or on a banana leaf as part of a Kerala thali, showcasing the colorful mix of vegetables.

Family Style

- A generous shared pot at festival gatherings, ladled over rice for each family member.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Cutting vegetables into uniform batons and staggering their cooking by firmness are both essential for the dish's characteristic texture.
- The raw coconut oil and curry leaves finish, rather than a hot tempering, is non-negotiable for authentic avial flavor.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Vegetables can be pre-cut a day ahead and refrigerated, ready for quick cooking when needed.
- The coconut paste can also be made ahead, though the dish is best finished and served relatively fresh.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Kerala cooks use sour raw mango instead of yogurt during the tangier mango season, giving a slightly different but equally traditional version of the dish.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

155 kcal	3 g	18 g	9 g	5 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Onam Sadya Avial	the classic festival version featured here, with the full traditional vegetable mix.
Mango Avial	made with sour raw mango instead of yogurt for tang, common in some Kerala households.
Simplified Avial	a home-cook shortcut using fewer vegetables when the full traditional mix isn't available.

Can I make avial without yam or raw banana?

Yes — substitute with what's available, such as extra pumpkin, carrot, or potato; the flavor will differ slightly but the dish remains delicious.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why did my yogurt split?

Almost always adding it while the pot was still over heat. Remove from heat completely before stirring in the yogurt.

Is avial very spicy?

No — it's mild, with warmth from green chili rather than significant heat, letting the coconut and vegetables take center stage.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Avial	a mixed vegetable dish in a coconut-yogurt sauce, central to Kerala cuisine.
Sadya	an elaborate Kerala vegetarian feast served on a banana leaf, especially for Onam.
Onam	Kerala's major harvest festival, when avial is a required dish.
Nendran	a specific plantain variety commonly used for the raw banana in this dish.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Avial

20m	25m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
6	Med
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

VEGETABLES

Raw banana	120 g
Yam	150 g
Carrot	80 g
Drumstick	80 g
Green beans	100 g
Pumpkin	130 g
Cucumber	60 g

COCONUT PASTE

Fresh coconut	100 g
Cumin seeds	4 g
Green chili	3–4
Turmeric powder	1.5 g

TO FINISH

Plain yogurt	120 g
Coconut oil	45 ml
Curry leaves	15–20 leaves
Salt	9 g

METHOD

01 **Cut all vegetables to similar sizes.** Cut all the vegetables into similar-sized batons, roughly 2 inches long and ½ inch thick — this uniformity is important for even cooking and the dish's traditional presentation.

02 **Cook the firmer vegetables first.** In a large pot, combine the yam, drumstick, and carrot with a small amount of water and turmeric.

03 **Add the remaining vegetables.** Add the raw banana, beans, pumpkin, and cucumber if using.

04 **Make the coconut paste.** Coarsely grind the coconut, cumin seeds, and green chilies together — a slightly textured, not perfectly smooth, paste is traditional for avial.

05 **Add the coconut paste to the vegetables.** Stir the coconut paste into the pot of cooked vegetables, along with salt.

06 **Stir in the yogurt.** Remove from heat and stir in the whisked yogurt — adding it off the heat prevents it from splitting.

07 **Finish with raw coconut oil.** Drizzle the coconut oil over the top and add the curry leaves, stirring gently to combine.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Raw banana	120 g	☐ Yam	150 g
☐ Carrot	80 g	☐ Drumstick	80 g
☐ Green beans	100 g	☐ Pumpkin	130 g
☐ Cucumber	60 g	☐ Fresh coconut	100 g
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Green chili	3–4
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Plain yogurt	120 g
☐ Coconut oil	45 ml	☐ Curry leaves	15–20 leaves
☐ Salt	9 g		

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